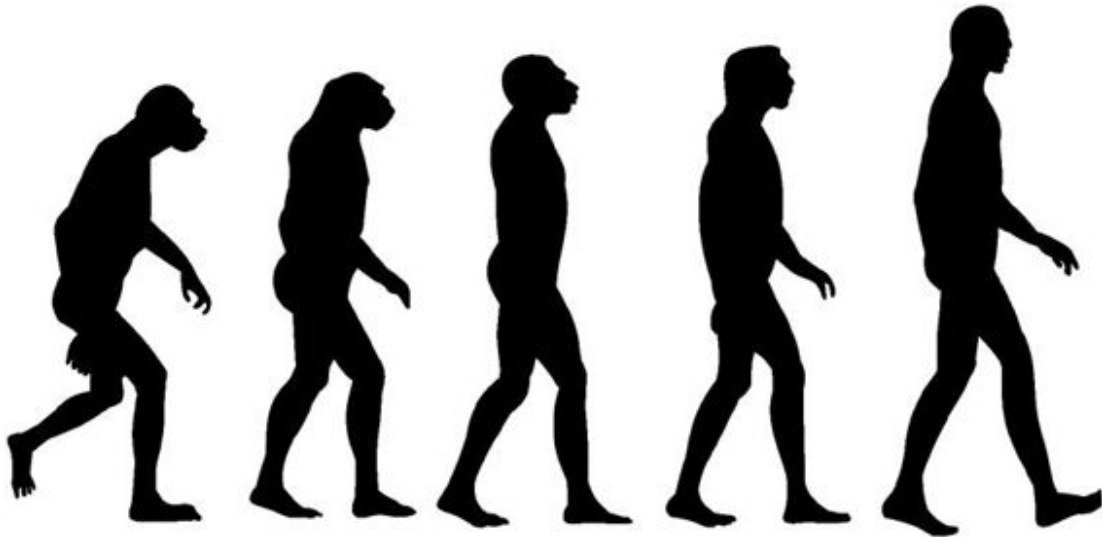


On the Origin of Species



The cultural influence of science reached a climax in the mid-19th century with the 1859 publication of Darwin's *On the Origin of Species*. Although it was a scientific rather than a philosophical work, his theory of evolution by natural selection put many aspects of philosophy in a new perspective. In the same way as Copernicus's proposal of a heliocentric universe challenged religious authority and became symbolic of emergent Renaissance humanism, Darwin's explanation of evolution presented humans as just another animal – part of the natural world rather than separate from it. In his later *Descent of Man*, he applied the principles of evolutionary theory specifically to humans, explicitly stating for the first time that we have evolved from animals, and so challenging previous notions of man as superior to other animals because of his ability to reason. But perhaps most important in terms of its effect on philosophy was the implicit idea that humans are not the pinnacle of God's creation, but merely a stage in the evolution of the natural world.